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‹ NO LOVE LOST
CM Gehlot with then deputy CM Sachin Pilot during an event in Jaipur, 2019

that Pilot was her choice. Maken, meanwhile, Gehlot's loyalists allege, had started reaching out to the MLAs to back Pilot. It was, however, Sonia Gandhi's decision that the Rajasthan CLP would authorise her to select the next CM that effectively sealed his exit from Rajasthan before the official elevation. The planned one-line resolution eliminated any scope for consultation with Gehlot. No one knows why the CLP was called hurriedly, but some insiders say the directive came from Priyanka Gandhi. "She first forced Navjot Singh Sidhu on Punjab and doomed the party," says a CWC member. "Now, she is trying to script another disaster in Rajasthan."

Maken's call on the night of September 24, seeking time from him for the CLP meeting, got Gehlot thinking on his feet. He became increasingly wary at Maken and Kharge's insistence on meeting the MLAs one-on-one. There was every possibility that the high command would project Pilot as their choice, and any MLA would yield to the pressure in a private, personal meeting. That's when Gehlot started planning his counter strike, determined that if he could not save his chair, he would not let Pilot have it either.

THE END GAME

Initial reports suggest that Sonia Gandhi was upset with Gehlot for the drama his MLAs orchestrated. Her anger was evident when she asked the disciplinary committee to take action within a couple of hours of Maken filing a written report on what had transpired in Jaipur on September 25. Showcause notices were served on three of Gehlot's closest aides—Dhariwal, Mahesh Joshi, the party chief whip in Rajasthan, and Rathore—on charges of grave indiscipline of convening a parallel CLP meeting. Joshi had allegedly asked MLAs to go to Dhariwal's house to discuss an urgent matter before proceeding to the CLP at the chief minister's residence in the evening.

At the same time, though, Sonia avoided taking any immediate direct action against Gehlot, keeping all options open. Her most trusted confidant, A.K. Antony, was summoned out of retirement in Kerala. The Congress could afford a repeat of Punjab, where the high command forced out incumbent chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh last year, following his power tussle with Navjot Singh Sidhu. It resulted in a Congress wipeout in the assembly polls this year. With Rajasthan heading for polls next year, a gamble gone wrong will make the party lose one of the two states it is currently in power on its own. Gehlot's position within the party was also far stronger than Amarinder's, who did not have the support of the MLAs.

After all, it was Gehlot who helped the party win three Rajya Sabha seats in June although Congress had the numbers just for two. All three elected members were from outside Rajasthan, chosen by the high command. "Six of the seven Rajya Sabha members were from outside Rajasthan. Yet we worked hard for their win. To accuse us then of indiscipline or not obeying the party is unfortunate," says Joshi.

The party contemplated damage control measures. Gehlot could remain the "chosen" presidential candidate, provided he announced he would step down as chief minister if he wins the presidential poll and recuse himself from the process of selecting the next CM. But the Family was unwilling to trust him again. "If he could rebel now and get away with it, he could have got bolder and cornered the Family once he became president," says a CWC member. "The Family has not forgotten how Narasimha Rao and Sitaram Kesri defied them."

The other problem before the high command was the rehabilitation of Pilot. Though there is no official confirmation, insiders claim that following his unsuccessful rebellion in 2020, the Gandhi siblings—Rahul and Priyanka—had promised Pilot the chief ministership of Rajasthan a year before the state goes to polls in 2023. Both Sonia and Priyanka had also duly noted Pilot's grievances in two separate meetings in the second week of September. And though he has not demonstrated any intent or strength to repeat his rebel act, the BJP is always on the lookout for a chance to embarrass the Congress. It has handsomely accommodated many of the Congress's young brigade—Jyotiraditya Scindia, Jitin Prasada, R.P.N. Singh. Pilot's departure will leave a dent in the Gujjar votebank he represents, which makes up 7 per cent of the electorate.

For the moment, Gehlot has withdrawn, tactically, as well as from the presidential race. He has also tendered an apology. But this is certainly not the last word in the drama. The shrewd politician would have made all his calculations well in advance, factoring in the damage he may suffer in the bargain. He has showed the high command what he is capable of. The next blow from the family will perhaps not be immediate, but it will certainly not be without preparation. If he does survive the crisis, Gehlot may well have offered the Congress a new working model for the post-Gandhi era. ■